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APPS



Design and development shop the Iconfactory is selling some apps — and AI is partially to blame



Sarah Perez — 10:36 AM PDT · July 31, 2025

At one point, an app called [Twitterrific](#) was one of the most popular iPhone apps for browsing Twitter. These days, the company behind that app, and the many apps that followed, is struggling. And AI may partially be to blame.

On Wednesday, the company known as the Iconfactory admitted it was at a crossroads and was putting up for sale a lot of its apps for sale due to a lack of resources. While the [announcement](#) positioned the matter as a situation where the company's app catalog had simply grown to include too many apps to keep up with and not enough time to do so, the reality is that the business today has no choice but to focus on the apps that offer a better return on investment.

Side products can no longer be maintained, even if they have "loads of happy and loyal customers," as the Iconfactory's co-founder, Ged Maheux, says.

The company says that it will continue to work on apps like [Tapestry](#), [Linea Sketch](#), [Wallaroo](#), and [Tot](#), as well as its new project involving [Retro Pixel Portraits](#), but is accepting "serious offers" for the other apps. These sales will include intellectual property and source code.

Of particular interest is that the company points to AI significantly affecting its business as the reason.

"ChatGPT and other AI services are basically killing @Iconfactory, and I'm not exaggerating or being

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hyperbolic,” Iconfactory developer Sean Heber [said in a Mastodon](#) post earlier this month.

The issue isn’t that people are using AI instead of mobile apps, but how vibe coding is affecting the need for app design firms like theirs. Besides building its own apps, the Iconfactory generated revenue by offering app [design services](#), which include things like icon design (hence the name), app design, marketing asset creation, plus branding and consulting services.

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These services helped fuel the business that’s now being destroyed by AI. “I know nothing I say is going to get anyone to stop using ChatGPT and generating a new app icon in 5 minutes for the app that you also had ChatGPT write for you in a few hours, but I’m not sure what the rest of us are supposed to do about making enough money to, ya know, live,” Heber wrote.

Another issue for the longtime app makers at the Iconfactory was the shutdown of its most popular

- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren’t even dating apps

app, Twitterrific, which was killed by Elon Musk in 2023 when the company (now known as X) [officially banned all third-party clients](#). The move put [Twitterrific](#), [Tweetbot](#), and other apps almost instantly out of business, leading the Iconfactory to [plead with its users to decline their App Store refunds](#) to help them stay afloat.

That, too, has affected the Iconfactory's future, Heber admitted in his posts.

"First Twitter/Elon killed our main app revenue that kept the lights on around here, then generative AI exploded to land a final blow to design revenue," he wrote. "I think perhaps because @Iconfactory design is quite good people have this impression that we're sitting here on a pile of money or something and some huge powerhouse — nope. We've been barely making it since Elon/Twitter. There's only 6 of us and there's no war chest."

After shutting down Twitterrific, the Iconfactory turned to the open social web as a way to generate a new revenue stream. It [launched an app called Tapestry](#), which allows users to track sources across the open web, including RSS feeds, YouTube, Bluesky, podcasts, Mastodon, Reddit, Tumblr, Micro.blog, and others. The app [offers a variety of clever tools](#) for organizing sources, making feeds, muting and hiding content you don't want to see, and more. It also offered a way for third-party developers to extend Tapestry with add-ons called Connectors, allowing users to add even more open feeds.

That app will remain a part of the company's efforts for now — a Mac app is in the works — but even its future could be uncertain. For one thing, open social media platforms like Mastodon and Bluesky are still dwarfed by tech giants, which means consumer demand for something like Tapestry is fairly niche.

As Heber [shared](#), the app's Kickstarter was a bit of a "Hail Mary" on the company's part, but people aren't subscribing in great enough numbers to make up for the revenue that Twitterrific once brought in, he said.

If AI continues to commoditize the business of app making, the Iconfactory won't be alone in suffering the consequences. But vibe-coded apps aren't necessarily what consumers need, not only because of the lack of human input, but also the [lax security](#) some of these apps offer.

Reached for comment, Maheux agreed that AI had "definitely put a damper on the design side of our services," though it hasn't "killed" the company yet.

"Many indie developers have adopted AI for an inexpensive or free solution for graphical work like app icons, which has been a core part of the services we offer. We still do, of course, but the frequency of developers coming to us for these services has declined greatly in the last few years," he told TechCrunch via email.

He also cited other factors impacting the business, like Apple's graphical system, SF Symbols, that developers can use instead. Consumers are tiring of subscriptions for everything. Plus, he points out that the cost of everything has increased over the years, while the cost of apps has not, making it harder to make a living as a small business developer.

"We've had to expand our offerings into other areas like UX consulting, coding consultation, and side revenue services to try and make up the revenue from this lost design work. Apple's introduction of Liquid Glass has offered some new opportunities for design work and consultation, and we've been working with a handful of companies on this, so that's been hopeful," he noted.

Updated after publication with company comment.

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APPS



Twitterrific's team is back with Tapestry, an app for tracking social media, news, RSS and more

PROJECT Tapestry

[The Iconfactory](#), the maker of a popular third-party Twitter client, [Twitterrific](#), [that was among those killed off by Twitter under Elon Musk's management](#), is hoping to recover from its losses with a new app that combines your social media, news feeds and alerts into one experience. The app, dubbed ["Project Tapestry" as it launches on Kickstarter](#), will support Twitter/X alternatives like Bluesky, Mastodon and Tumblr, and possibly Instagram Threads when its developer API becomes available. However, it won't support X itself due to the [company's ban on third-party apps](#).

A working prototype of Project Tapestry has already been developed and if The Iconfactory is able to raise \$100,000 in funding through Kickstarter it will further develop the app to be launched to the public.

IMAGE CREDITS: THE ICONFACTORY

[As described](#), Project Tapestry is meant to organize today's fragmented online media into one interface, by allowing users to follow a variety of sources in one place. For instance, you could track your favorite blogs, news sites, social networks and webcomics, as well as critical updates that used to come via Twitter, like weather alerts or earthquake warnings.

This would involve working with any site that offers an RSS feed, which most blogs and news sites (without a paywall) already do. It would also integrate with the startups that are offering Twitter alternatives, like Bluesky, powered by the new AT Protocol, and Mastodon, which will be powered by another emerging web standard, ActivityPub. (The company isn't planning on Threads support at

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launch, but would consider adding it, as well, if an API was made available, we're told.)

Other planned sources include Tumblr, Micro.blog, USGS Earthquakes, NOAA Satellite and GO Comics. Facebook and Instagram will not be available, though.

After setup, Tapestry would organize all your updates into one feed, displayed in chronological order. Plus, the app could remove duplicates to cut down on the clutter — like when someone posts a link to multiple social networks at once. In the new app, those mentions could be combined, so you only see the post one time.

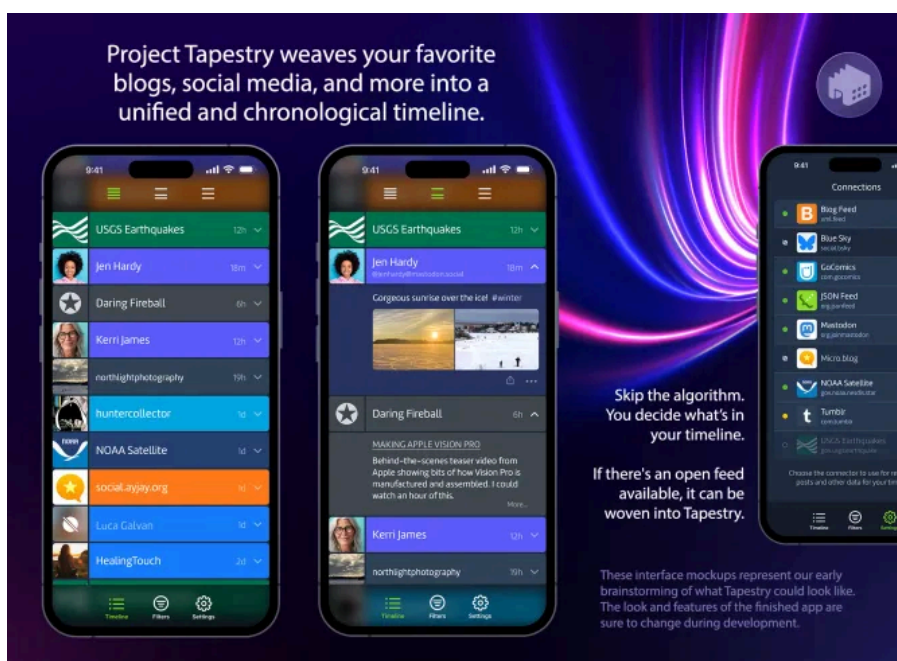


IMAGE CREDITS: THE ICONFACTORY

The team envisions making Project Tapestry's timeline something that anyone could integrate with by writing plug-ins using JavaScript that will translate between the web and the native iOS app. For example, developers tinkering around with Raspberry Pi could send custom alerts to their timeline via this interface.

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Other notable features include the ability to mark items as read, remember your reading position in the timeline, support for light and dark themes, and a couple more copied over from the company's Twitterrific days — like muting and “muffling.” The latter [was a popular option for those who wanted to know what was being said](#) by minimizing the tweets, and providing a short description of what was hidden instead.

If the company's stretch goal of \$150,000 is reached on Kickstarter, the team will also work on a more advanced search feature that would allow you to search across the sources and social networking posts you already follow instead of the wider web. That aspect sounds particularly promising at a time when Google Search's quality is [diminishing due to SEO spam](#) and [AI-written pages](#).

This isn't the first time Iconfactory has turned to Kickstarter. It also used the site to fund the development of Twitterrific for Mac in 2017, which was funded in 20 days.

Though Iconfactory today makes several apps for creativity, entertainment and gaming, the shutdown

of Twitterrific had been difficult for the company and its team.

Laments The Iconfactory's Principal/Designer [Gedeon Maheux](#), the new project came about because the team "had invested so much time and energy into Twitter," but then Twitter "wall[ed] up their garden and people like us were forced to leave," he says. "Now you have friends that are on different services, different places, and it's hard to keep track of them."

The need for crowdsourced funds was also necessary because of the loss of Twitterrific.

"The death of Twitterrific really hurt...Killing third-party Twitter apps really put a dent in [our revenue] because Twitterrific was one of our bread-and-butter apps. It really fueled development and allowed us to do these things that we loved," notes Maheux. Since Twitterrific's shutdown, he says, the company has not yet been able to "close the gap."

"Hopefully, Tapestry will help with that," he adds.

Twitterrific may not be a household name like Twitter once was, but the app had a [sizable influence on Twitter culture](#).

The Twitter client was one of the earliest on the market and began [using a bird logo](#), which other clients then adopted, too. Later, Twitter started using a bird as its official logo in 2010. The Iconfactory also contributed the word "tweet" to the vocabulary around using Twitter, and created a [workaround for Twitter's lack of an "Edit" button in 2014](#) by creating a feature that would delete and repost a tweet, giving the appearance of edits.

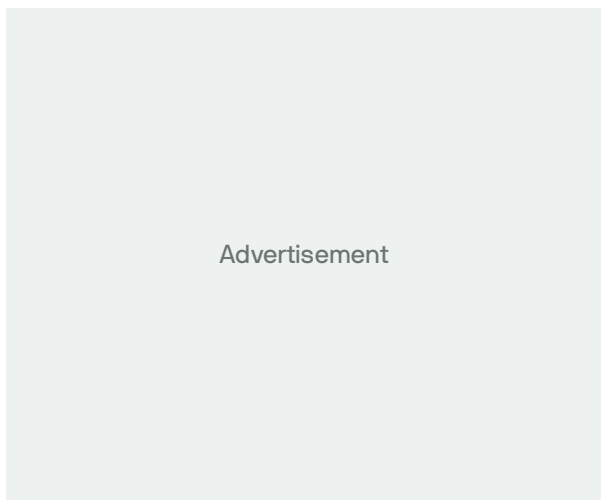
With its understanding of how to tap into the market of social apps, Tapestry has the potential to now solve new pain points for users who are leaving Twitter/X — a way to track the news, people and

information that matter to them, no matter where they go.

The [\\$100,000 Kickstarter goal](#) will allow The Iconfactory to get the initial app done and made public via the App Store. Since launching the crowdsourced funding plea this morning, they’ve raised over \$46,000.

The company has historically been averse to the idea of taking venture capital, as it wants to remain independent, but if Tapestry takes off after going public, Maheux admits it’s “never say never” when it comes to raising outside funds. In the meantime, however, if you want to use an app like Tapestry, you’ll have to [donate](#) toward its creation.

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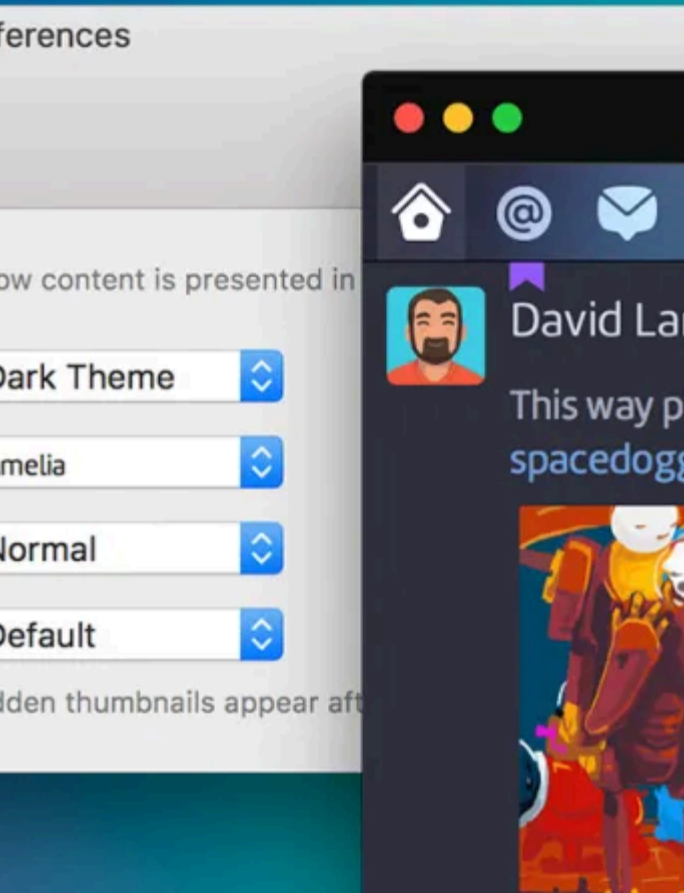


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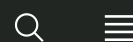
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Twitterrific returns to Mac as a customizable Twitter client, but at twice the price of Tweetbot

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establish demand for a Mac app ahead of devoting developer resources to building it.

Today, [Twitterrific 5 for Mac](#) has gone live, and includes a number of features like a dark mode, themes, support for multiple timelines and accounts, syncing with its iOS counterpart, customizable fonts and type sizes, and more.

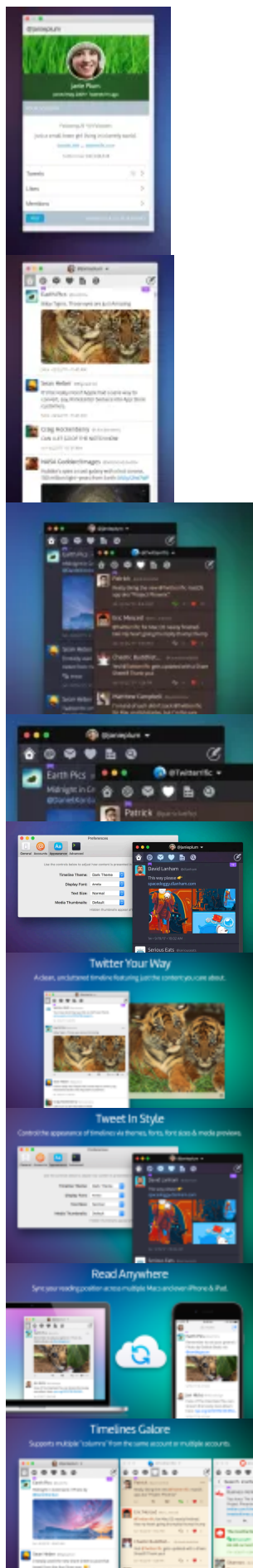
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Google denies AI search features are killing website traffic

Sarah Perez - 11 hours ago

The client has also been built with macOS integrations in mind, including support for Notification Center, Retina displays, built-in sharing, full screen mode, and other features.



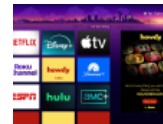
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Longtime Twitter users will remember there was once a time when the landscape was rife with third-party Twitter clients, including Twitterrific, Tweetbot, and many more. But shortly after Twitter [snapped up Tweetie in 2010](#) to form the basis of its own mobile app, it [overhauled its API Terms of Service in 2011](#), effectively telling developers to stop building their own third-party Twitter apps.

Twitter then [picked up TweetDeck for \\$40 million](#) to save it from being acquired by UberMedia. But the app hasn't received as much [attention in recent months](#), as Twitter is focused more on mobile and web than it is on desktop.

The Twitterrific Mac app was first released a decade ago, but stopped being updated in 2013 as the team followed the money to mobile.

There's still a small, but devoted crowd interested in a Twitterrific Mac app, however, as the Kickstarter proved.



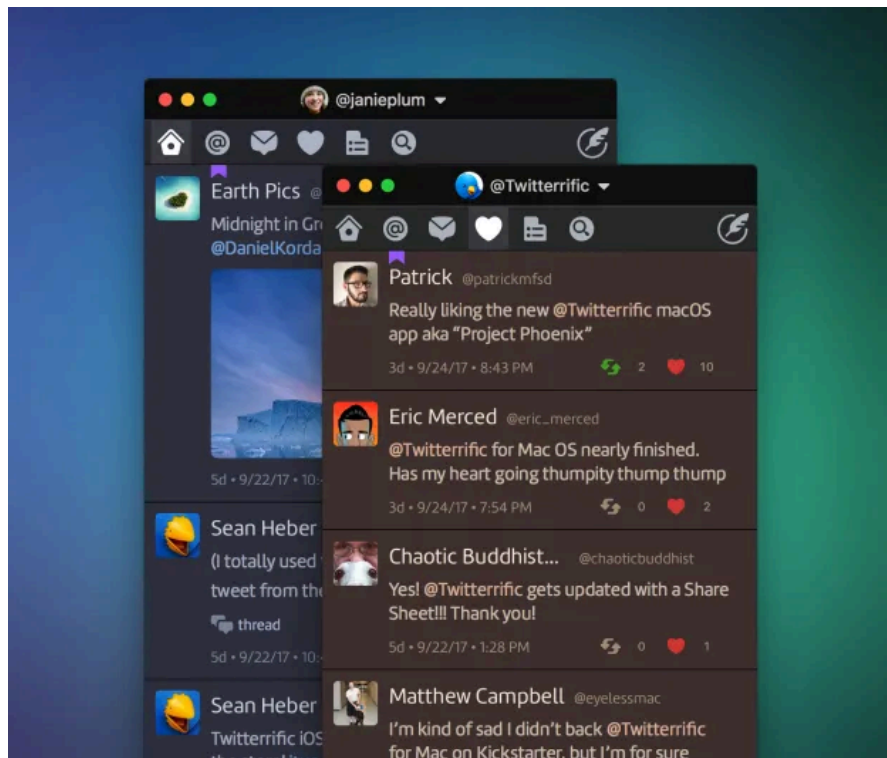
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But at double the price of a rival third-party client for Mac, Tweetbot, Iconfactory has priced its software to appeal to a niche audience whose fondness for Twitterrific hadn't faded over the years. (Its new app is \$19.99 compared with just \$9.99 for Tweetbot.)



That said, the app delivers a good handful of features Mac users will like, beyond standard items like support for multiple panes, and access to Twitter's main features like mentions, DMs, favorites, retweets, quote tweets, trending topics, saved searches, lists, and more.

It also makes it easier to follow chained tweets and "tweet storms," while adding in-demand features Twitter itself doesn't have, like the ability to edit your tweets, for example. (To be clear, Twitter doesn't allow for tweet editing natively, so Twitterrific's implementation is a workaround – it deletes the tweet you need to correct with the new one you've edited. Still, it's handy.)

Different types of tweets are color-coded in Twitterrific as well, allowing you to quickly differentiate regular tweets from replies, DMs and your own updates. And the app is quite customizable, too, with support for things like light and dark themes, the ability to control font type and

size, which windows you want to see, and what content you don't.

For those with the Twitterrific iOS version, the app will sync your reading position between devices, plus your mutes and muffles, [a lighter version of muting](#).

The app also promises an ad-free experience without other clutter like Twitter's "While You Were Away" catch-ups or other people's tweets in the timeline. (Twitter doesn't currently serve ads through its API, so third-party apps like Twitterrific don't show them. But that could change.)

Kickstarter backers received the new Twitterrific for Mac app at a discounted price, and in some cases, were able to beta test. The public release at \$19.99 may be a tougher sell among other mainstream Mac users, however, given the competition from both Tweetbot and the free Tweetdeck app.

[vimeo 237408313 w=640 h=360]

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APPS



Tweetbot and Twitterrific ask customers to decline refunds in rare App Store exception

Sarah Perez — 3:24 PM PST · March 1, 2023

Twitter last month [officially banned third-party clients](#), putting a [sudden end to popular apps](#), including [Tweetbot](#), [Twitterrific](#), and others. Now, in an unusual turn of events, two developers this week have updated their shuttered apps with new functionality: They're asking their subscribers to decline to receive a refund by clicking a new "I don't need a refund" button in their nonfunctional apps. And, in the case of Tapbots' Tweetbot app, users can opt to transfer their subscription to the company's newest app — [its Mastodon client Ivory](#) — instead. The options allow subscribers who are sympathetic to these indie developers' plight to offer support by not asking for their money back.

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It's an unprecedented situation, to say the least, and one most subscription-based iOS apps wouldn't ever have to face.

In most other scenarios, a company's decision to put an end to API access, as Twitter did, would have been telegraphed well in advance. This would allow the businesses dependent on the API functionality to communicate with their customers about the change and prepare to take the next steps. The third-party Twitter clients, however, had no warning.

Twitter didn't communicate ahead of its API changes, and it didn't even admit to what it had done as the user and developer backlash grew. After initially ignoring the complaints, the company later tweeted that it was only "enforcing its long-standing API rules." But those rules [weren't documented](#) in its [developer terms](#) until after the API access had been yanked. Whatever "long-standing" rules Twitter was referring to still remains unclear. (Perhaps it was that time, [12 years ago](#), when the company told developers to stop trying to compete by building clients? Who knows!)

Twitter officially bans third-party clients after cutting off prominent devs



After cutting off prominent app makers like Tweetbot and Twitterrific, Twitter today quietly updated its developer terms to ban third-party clients altogether. Spotted by Engadget, the

"restrictions" section of Twitter's 5,000-some-word developer agreement was updated with a clause prohibiting "use or access the Licensed Materials to create or attempt to create a substitute or similar ... [Continue reading](#)

While Twitter may have never fully embraced the idea that there were apps offering alternative experiences, it ultimately decided to leave these particular third-party apps alone, even [as it cracked down](#) on other API usages. Twitter, it had seemed,

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begudgingly acknowledged the apps' long history of [contributing positively to the ecosystem](#). Plus, they supported some of Twitter's most devoted users.



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Though the apps' respective user bases were small compared to Twitter's official app, they were large enough to help sustain the indie developers' businesses. Like most subscription apps, they also monetized by way of monthly and annual subscriptions on the App Store. That means when Twitter pulled the plug, the companies were left in the unfortunate position of having their expected income almost immediately halted. And in the case of annual subscribers who paid upfront for a year's service, they would soon have to issue out-of-pocket refunds.

Both apps — Tapbots' Tweetbot and The Iconfactory's Twitterrific — rolled out app updates on Monday, according to their App Store pages. And now both apps feature similar wording around the requests they put to their subscribers.

In Tweetbot, for example, there are a handful of options to choose from. The top option allows paying customers to click a button to transfer their subscription to the company's new app, Ivory. A second option reads "I am happy with what I got out of Tweetbot and do not need a refund," and provides a big, blue "I Don't Need a Refund" button to click. A third option directs customers who do want a pro-rated refund to do nothing — the refund will be automated through Apple, which is the usual course of action.



Brent Simmons

@brentsimmons@indieweb.social

If you've used Twitterrific and/or Tweetbot and have a subscription — then this is your chance to be awesome and support awesome indie developers.

Here's what to do: get the latest versions from the App Store, launch the app, and then tap the "I Don't Need a Refund" button.

What is only a few dollars to you ends up, in aggregate, meaning a ton to these folks who work so hard and bring so much to our computing lives.



Transfer Tweetbot Sub to Ivory

*Your subscription will not auto-renew.

2. I am happy with what I got out of Tweetbot and do not need a refund.

If you've been happy with the service we've provided over the years and don't need us to send you a pro-rated refund back, you can choose this option.



I Don't Need a Refund*

*Your eligibility to request a refund from Apple is not affected by this option.

3. I want a pro-rated refund.

If you want a refund for the remaining subscription time, simply do nothing. We will

Meanwhile, Twitterrific's message is nearly the same but doesn't offer a subscription transfer option. Unlike Tapbots, the company didn't build a Mastodon client that would make sense as a new destination for subscribers' funds. Like Tweetbot, Twitterrific also presents an option that reads "I am satisfied with what I got out of Twitterrific and do not want a refund at this time," with a blue button below to click for those who agree. Customers who do want their pro-rated refund are again informed Apple will refund them.

What's more, Twitterrific provides links at the bottom of the screen to other Iconfactory apps and, not surprisingly, to its Mastodon account.

What's interesting is that neither company could officially comment on their updates, which indicates Apple likely made a special exception here to its usual App Store rules. (We were directed to reach out to Apple PR for comment, but we haven't heard back.)

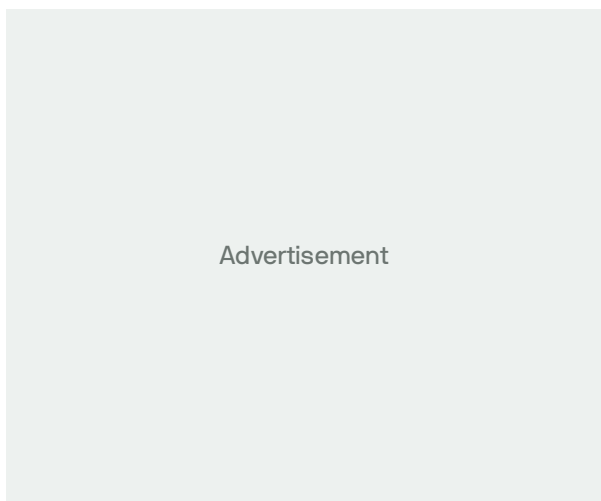
There aren't too many other situations where apps would be permitted to ask for what are effectively donations by way of subscription payments for nonfunctional apps. But given the high-profile nature of what happened with Twitter, it makes sense that Apple allowed these apps to make such requests.

Of course, this unique situation requires subscribers to redownload the apps — or update them if still installed — then click the button to stop the otherwise automatic pro-rated refund from occurring. This isn't ideal. These companies did no wrong and yet will now have to delve into their own pockets to pay out many refunds because a number of customers won't know to open these apps again in the first place.

[Twitterrific, Tweetbot and other clients begin offloading their apps after Twitter shuts them out](#)

[Tapbots launches a new Mastodon client, Ivory, after Twitter kills its Tweetbot app](#)

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